Q&A with Nisaba Godrej and Omar Momin with Dakshana Scholars at Dakshana Valley on July 25, 2025

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Mohnish: Well great to be here. Are you enjoying the monsoon? Alright. We have two guests with us today. We have Nisa Godrej from the Godrej family. And we have Omar Momin who has been with the Godrej in different roles and capacities since he finished college. Right from the beginning?

Omar: Yeah.

Mohnish: Yeah. Right from engineering. So, who has the first question?

Karthik: Hello ma'am good morning. I am Karthik Kumar from JNV Bijnor Uttar Pradesh. My question to you is how can we see our nation as a developed country in the future? Does it only depend on the working of the government, or can an individual also contribute to it? If yes, then what can I do for that initially? Thank you, Ma'am.

Nisaba: Thank you for that question. Thank you for having me here today. I am really excited to be here with all of you, and that excitement is because of, the way you are asking this question. But you all really are the future of the country, and obviously the government plays a huge part in change. But don't forget we elect the government so the more educated and thoughtful we are the better governments we ask for and it's not just at the central level, state level, district levels. I think with the education you all are getting and the effort that you are putting in to get that education and the top schools that you will go to then the opportunity for change, if you are going into something like business. Business creates jobs, it creates opportunities. You can see what Mohnish has done here. Correct. You create companies, you create wealth and then you can give back beyond the company also. So, I think there are lots of opportunities that an individual can have. A lot of you will study science and engineering. Again, innovation coming up with new ways of doing all things can create a lot of change. And, but there are two opportunities in life. Obviously creating this change, creating wealth, creating innovation. But the second thing is do we do it in a moral way do we do it with deep character and that is also the importance of education. So, I hope you all are studying science and engineering very hard. But you are also growing to be good human beings. Because like when we think of things like AI, it's going to really change the world. But, in whose hands it is, will depend on how that change also happens.

Mohnish: Next question.

Arti: My question to you is, What qualities a teenager must acquire to become a successful businessman. Explain by giving your example, what qualities you have acquired to become such a great and successful businesswomen. Thank you.

Nisaba: Thank you. I don't think I had many of the traits when I was a teenager. So I'm not sure about that, but I think one thing I heard here today is that they have taken away your phones. For this year. So, that's a definitely great start. There is one step of traits that makes us successful, because we are all quite different and the paths to success are quite different. But it looks some of the basic things that I would say it's important is, hard work, dedication is the glory. So, if we want to make something of our life and of the world, we have to put in the work in the hours and it takes time to be like, you all can see you are doing this one-year intense coaching. So, to become do it and take it. We really have to put in the hours and work. The second piece is tenacity, grit, the ability to hold on. And I am sure lots of you have around it. Life keep throwing. Can I use the word shit at you. And the people who are successful, learn how to brush it off learn how to get up and go again. And then true success is also someone who has good moral character because things like money and all. You can make it by knowing sometimes not also having things like authenticity and trust and integrity but that is very important people who give we have an example sitting right in front. Do you give more than you take, when you are here, I know you are all trying to get the highest marks and to go to great schools but I would be very interested to know these students among you and I am sure that who help others along the way. Correct. You are coaching your friends along the way you are taking people with you. So I think that is super important also for success. That you are not only for your own success. You are also dedicated. You have a bigger purpose than yourself. But I didn't have any of these traits when I was a teenager. So, I am sure you all are doing much better than I am.

Alok: Hello ma'am. I am Alok from GB SSS Tikri Kala Delhi and my question to you is having interacted with a wide range of individuals across the different fields, What is the single most defining thing you have noticed in the individuals who truly stand out and what steps can one take to develop that trait personally. Thank you.

Nisaba: It feels like I should be like this is the secret of success. I wish I had that I don't. But if I look at it people I have come across and what is really stands out to me is, I use this word called spikiness. So, what is that person really spiky and what are they really excellent at? Some of it comes from we have some talent. Maybe it was just very musical. And then we really spent the hard work in terms of developing that spikiness. But I think whether it's in business, whether it's in medicine, whether it's In what do you bring to the table, that really makes people stand up and notice and brings value to them. So I don't think it's the same thing for everyone but can you understand what that is in yourself and really develop it and then because it's so strong other people can see it. So, when you see a lot of different successful people in different ways that really comes back and I'm sorry for sounding like everybody like grandma and granny but I'll come back to the bit on values and moral character. I think that really,

stands out for me. That's when people do what they do with real integrity. Correct that's what he asked about what will shift our country forward. I think those are and you and you see it in the history of countries. Correct. Who are the people who come and give us a thinking of the future which is not just about GDP, growth and success. That's also very important. But give us a thinking of the future which is a which brings more justice and equality and like the people who wrote the Constitution of India they had those thoughts they move us forward so both those things are really being spiky and excellent at what you do but also I see someone with a sense of character and justice that moves those ideas forward also.

Omar: I just want to add in terms of my answer to that question actually would be curiosity. Right? So I think in this year you have to focus on your exams and you have to kind of get things done as per what's needed. But once you're through I think what you'll find is the people who succeeded the most, are those who are curious about the world, right? So, whatever topic you like, you're currently not taught the history of physics or the history of mathematics, right? But when you kind of go out and try and start doing things, try and understand everything you can, about whatever you're doing, and don't stop being curious. The world is deeply complex, it's huge and just keep that spirit alive of always wanting to understand whatever is around you as best as you can.

Mohnish: Okay, next question.

Rishika: Hello ma'am, good morning. I am Rishika Raj from JNV, Aurangabad Bihar. My question is since you have contributed a lot to the society so could you please suggest us some possible initiative that we as a student can take and give back to the society?

Nisaba: Thank you for that question. I think depending on what age we are and where we are in our life there is always opportunities to pass it forward. So, for example I am involved in a non-profit called Teach for India and they take very bright 24, 25-year-olds from some of the best universities and colleges in India and then they put them for two years in government schools and they call it teach to live. So, they hope that this is what they call Teach For India Fellows will really learn about the system at the ground. And, really transform those children like, that eventually, one of the Fellows right now is in the Punjab government working on education. So, they have ground reality but then they go into leadership positions to change things. So, there are things like, you can do a fellowship. You can dedicate two years to doing that and then you can have jobs that can really create a change. But I think I can imagine that young people like you must be so inspiring to people just within your Communities, within your families, I'm sure that their brothers and sisters and cousins, whose lives will change because you have blessed the path beforehand. So, change, you don't have to start with saying how will I change India, I hope some future prime minister, finance minister sitting here. But it can start in every day, correct like the gifts that we have been given what can we do with it so with in our own village, town, in our neighbourhood can we start with you coaching kids there passing it forward. So, there is lots of opportunities throughout life and just what kindness you are doing every day and it starts from there.

Mohnish: Okay next question.

Arpit: Hello ma'am. My name is Arpit Suman from JNV Rajgir Nalanda, Bihar and my question to you is could you please suggest your thoughts that, Is it possible to establish a financially sustainable and profitable medical setup in India that can provide best medical services to the economically weaker sections at the least possible cost.

Nisaba: You have obviously thought of this more than me you should answer this question. Is that something you want to do like as a business?

Arpit: Yes ma'am, but I want suggestions financially. Is it possible financially, profitable and sustainable.

Nisaba: Yeah, I definitely, I actually think that both in education and health care with something like AI there is going to be a real revolution, and India is full of people and full of data. So, how do we leverage that? How do we build systems and businesses where you bring the cost down to serve people? And because that's what you need. Correct scale and efficiency. So, it should be possible and these are like, areas that if you're passionate about, there's so much need for it. And if we can bring high quality at accessible prices that could be amazing. One of the things I always ask Omar is that, one of the products we make is soap. And soap is one of the products that 99% of Indians use. So, most Indians get to use high quality soap and we are able to do it at cost because of efficiency at a price that people can afford and we sort of talk about why we can't get things like education and health care. At more affordable prices and unfortunately the government has not been able to solve for some of these things. But, can private entrepreneurship play a role in it. Correct? Either using some government infrastructure or completely separately.

Omar: So, there is an organization called Arvind Eye Care. And there is a book about them that you can look up and read. But the insight that they had in terms of how they make this happen. Which is Eye care at scale for everyone despite being profitable is because when you do surgeries and procedures at huge scale you not only do it at a low cost but you build such high levels of expertise in the surgeons who are doing it that even the rich people want to come there and then you have two kinds of models where the rich people pay for the expertise and the poor people get it almost free and in total it still is a sustainable setup. So, you might want to read more about them.

Mohnish: So that book is called Infinite Vision. So, I will just give you a couple of stories from the book just to help you understand in the Arvind Hospital. I visited their hospital a few years back with my mom and my daughter and had a nice trip. They have two entrances. One entrance is free. One entrance is paid. And Arvind doesn't tell you which entrance to go. You decide and they do not ask any questions like Dakshana ask lot of questions, what is your income, what is this, what is that. They ask no questions If you are a rich person and you want to have a free surgery you can go to the free side. The surgeon in the middle who is doing the surgery is the same for both sides. But on the free side you can't go with a family member you have to go alone. There are no chairs you sit on the ground. So, some difference is there but the surgery there is no difference. And what doctor V did is, one time he was visiting the United States. And he notices that in McDonalds the restaurant all this food was

prepared with no chef. There is no chef in McDonalds. They have taken some person train them for four five days and the person is producing whatever food they are giving because what they have done is they have a standard process how do you produce French fries, how do you produce a sandwich, how do you do this, how do you do that. They train the person to do that and that person start producing. That is all they can do so what he did in Arvind Eye care, he said what is the need of a doctor so he looks at every single part of the process for doing a cataract surgery and he eliminated the doctor in 80% of the stuff that other places were using a doctor for and they put two beds in the same room for the doctor when the doctors are working on one patient the second patient is being prepared by the nurses. Then the microscope moves over to the other side, and then this patient goes and they bring The next patient. Every eight minutes the doctor is doing a new surgery. The number of surgeries Arvind eye care doctor does I mean in the US doctor will do four or five cataract surgeries in a day. This is like five or six an hour seven an hour. And they might do 50-60 surgeries in a day. So, obviously the cost is coming down. There is another model which is Narayana model. They actually are funding part of what Dakshina is getting. They are getting some money from Narayana. And they did the same thing for heart. For different things related to the heart. So I think that if you study the Arvind model, you can even visit there. That model actually can be replicated for every body organ. There is a lot of scope. All the best. Okay. Yes. Next question.

Nisaba: I just had something to add to that too. I think the opportunity also in doing something like medical care is one of the things in India we don't have enough medical care, but we also don't have enough jobs. So if you can do some of these things successfully, you can create a lot of scale. And I just had an example of someone I know really well. Actually a family member, who's sister is American and she told her you are wasting so much time in America going in circles because of their insurance system. How the doctors are sending you. Why don't you come to India for two days. And you can do all your tests in Bombay in a hospital and you will be finished in a day. And what's beautiful about this Arvind Eye Hospital is that there is paid and then there is free. Correct. So, on one side you can make money. Which can go to subsidize the other side also. And the problems are there for rich people also. Like if someone is coming from New York. So, in medical you are just serving people you can know you create jobs and you can create a lot of financial value also, so good luck.

Mohnish: Our former president Dr Kalam accidentally went into the free section at Arvind. He went to get his cataract surgery does, he didn't understand about the entrances. He just walked in, and he his procedure was done on the free side city on the floor and all that he was very happy he got no issues worked well. Next question.

Parmar Javis: Hello ma'am good morning. My name is Parmar Jevis Deepak Kumar. I am from JNV Panchmahal Gujarat. My question to you is to what extent should we consider our peers and others advice while taking career decisions? Additionally, could you please share some tips for learning financial management while still being in college? Thank you, ma'am.

Nisaba: Thank you for your question. Listening to people who have gone ahead of you getting advice. Networking to find out what opportunities are

there is very important. But I would say listening to your own heart. And your own knowing inside is even more important. Correct. Because a lot of times you will be told, this is not possible for you. But no one can tell you what is possible for you. You don't know what's possible for you without trying. So, it's very very important to have a network, to have mentors to take advice. But even if you want to go far you have to go with other people. But you have to do that. That inner knowing or that inner courage also because don't forget that we will fail as we go a long in life, but I think you have to listen to your inner voice. Next question.

Khushi: I am Khushi from Dr. B. R. Ambedkar SOSE, Karol Bagh in Delhi. Since you studied abroad. You must have interacted with the students there, what difference do you observe between the students in other countries and students in India, Are there any good practices and qualities from abroad that we as Indian students can adopt to improve ourselves?

Nisaba: Culturally we might be different, but we are all human beings. So, eventually you can learn about a lot of different cultures but fundamentally we have many similarities. From an education system. There is a lot to learn, and Omar spoke about curiosity. I don't know whether we should be sharing this in the year that you how to be focused and studying. So maybe next year after you all get into IIT or after you graduate. But no, what he is saying in terms of curiosity is that, the Indian system is very focused on your grades and marks and things like that. Which is also very important. But, studying abroad what you realize is that they broaden your mind set a lot, and there is a lot of value in subjects like learning about history and comparative literature and so there is a lot of value given to that and as you get older what you realize is that being a well rounded human being so being excellent at your subject and excellent at engineering but also having an understanding of the world because if you look at something like history, you say it might not be applicable today like engineering is applicable today, but it's very applicable because we keep making the same mistakes over and over again in history, correct in the people we vote into leadership and things like that. So, I do think it's what Omar was saying it's curiosity. But that comes from I really think these phones and social media and they've been built. So, you get addicted and then people like us can then advertise our products to you once you're addicted on those phones. So, if you really think about your day to day life i don't think you need an education abroad or people from abroad to influence that is, are you reading enough books are you growing your mind in other ways besides just what you are studying in your curriculum and today the world is available to us all the information is out there so you may be thinking it's every year what two new subjects that I deep dive into that i am interested in how many books did I read this year and I think you get that broadness from that.

Mohnish: Next question.

Simran: Good morning, I am Simran from JNV Pathankot, Punjab and my question to is that who is your role model in your life?

Nisaba: Who is my role model? I have had many role models in my life may be I will talk about my father, because he is the most Omar also knows him really well. My father is a role model for me because for a few reasons he

was just very deep, like deep integrity. So, I remember even in business like, it didn't matter whether there was a contract signed or not. Correct. There was always the principles of how you are fair to everyone on both sides. People who work with you people you are negotiating with. So, this is a very high sense of to keep your word. Correct like your word is stronger than any contract. This it is discipline and hard work. It was amazing to see that someone and discipline is about the everyday. Correct that you wake up and that you so sort of put in that work every day. And just a lot of humility, no ego. So, just, or I learned a lot from him. But I think, he used to tell me that like waking up like going to bed every night and you can sleep peacefully when you know you've always done the right thing that day. Correct. So, this sense of how important integrity is to your own peace and to what you put out in the world? Yeah. And for all the men here and may be for the women also. He was a real gentleman. And a real feminist. So I'm very lucky. As a woman especially in a country like India, which can be quite patriarchal that I grew up with a very feminist and a gallantarian father, so, I didn't realise that when I was younger because I thought all families would be the same but as I get older. But I want to stop now because I could talk about him for a while. And then I might start crying also.

Mohnish: We can do one more last question. Last Question.

Suraj: Hello Ma'am, Good Morning. I am Suraj Bhartiya from JNV Gandhinagar, Gujarat and my question to you is, how does the Indian education system differ from that of other developed countries like the USA, UK, China and Russia. What key reforms are most needed in your education system to ensure meaningful progress thank you.

Nisaba: Thank you for that question. I think at the higher levels if you look at the IITs and some of ours IIMs like the best schools in India, the quality of education would be extremely high. I don't think we have the kind of research at universities that you do abroad. Although, Trump is trying to do a way with that now in countries like the US. Which is very unfortunate. Because a lot of research whether its in the sciences, in engineering comes out of universities and then actually in medicine and then has been commercialized by companies and developed countries. In India, where we have really failed ourselves and our children is in our primary and secondary government education. I think in more developed countries you actually get literate and properly educated. So, that really is a problem for us to solve. 60% of India's now private education, 50% even, these low-cost private schools. But there outcomes are not much ahead of the government. So, I think that is both a challenge, but it's also an opportunity which we do need to solve.

Mohnish: Alright it was a lot of fun. Thank you so much. Thank you, Nisa, it was wonderful and thank you Omar.

Nisaba: Thank you. It was such a pleasure to meet all of you and thank you for preparing the questions and asking them so kindly. Thank you.

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